

few key imports such as grain and olive oil. The central desert regions of the Arabian peninsula were very poor: Bedouin tribes followed a nomadic lifestyle, and competition for scarce resources shaped a society in which primary loyalty was to a kinship group, or tribe.

At the time of Muhammad, Arabia was in a state of religious and political ferment. Strong Jewish communities had become established in Yemen in the south and in northwestern oasis towns, such as Medina, while Christianity had gained footholds in Yemen and eastern Arabia. Although monotheistic faiths were making inroads against the traditional polytheistic paganism of the Bedouin Arabs, paganism still remained strong. Conflict between tribes was also common, and in Mecca, in the sacred enclosure known as the *haram*, a truce was enforced so men of different tribes could trade freely without violence.

Muhammad in Mecca

The Meccan *haram* was controlled by the powerful Quraysh clan, of which Muhammad was a member. Muhammad's rejection of paganism, and his bold proclamation that there was but a single God, and that believers needed to follow a prescribed set of religious observances—including praying five times a day and fasting during Ramadan—set his followers apart. His preaching of a single religious community that cut across social boundaries was perceived as threatening by the traditional leaders, who felt it undermined the source of their authority.

The flight to Medina

By 622, the atmosphere in Mecca had become so tense that Muhammad and his handful of followers fled north to Medina—an event called the *hijra* (meaning immigration), which marked the real foundation of the Islamic community. The Medinans, who resented the power of the Mecca-based Qurayshi, were sympathetic to Muhammad's cause and allowed him to preach freely, giving him the opportunity to attract further converts.

The Qurayshi were not content to see Muhammad's power base grow in Mecca and within two years violence had broken out between the established powers there and Muhammad's supporters. Muhammad outmaneuvered the Qurayshi, first by raiding their caravans, then defeating them in a pitched battle in 627, and finally negotiating the right to return to Mecca on a pilgrimage in 629. By the time he died in 632, Muhammad was reestablished in Mecca, and his diplomatic and military successes in attracting other tribes to his cause had made his position unassailable. As his authority spread, so, too, did the reach of his religious message and the numbers of new Muslim converts.

After Muhammad's death, Islam entered a crisis and the fledgling religion might easily have been crushed. Tribes in the east broke away from the Muslim religious community (the *umma*) and declared allegiance to one of their commanders, while the Medinans were unhappy about the dominance of Meccans in the movement. The choice of Abu Bakr, »

Muhammad

The Prophet Muhammad was born in Mecca around 570 CE to a branch of the influential Quraysh tribe. Tradition relates that he was an orphan, whose first marriage to a wealthy widow named Khadijah secured his economic future. The religious revelations that were imparted to

Muhammad over a period of more than 20 years from about 610—and which were later written down as the Quran—caused a rupture with the traditional Meccan elites when he began to preach against pagan polytheism and practices such as female infanticide. Muhammad's flight to Medina in 622 marked a key moment in the spread of Islam, as its acceptance

outside Mecca showed that its appeal might transcend traditional kinship structures. Muhammad proved an inspirational leader, and his adept handling of the challenges facing the new religion meant that by the time of his death in 632, two years after imposing his rule on Mecca, its adherents had spread throughout Arabia.